

SONICS
NOT SO
SUPER
Bullets
bring end
to Seattle's
14-game
win streak
B3



NBA

Bulls know how
to blend egos

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BASEBALL

Elyria's Tarrence Staton
faces pivotal season

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Upsets abound
in the Big Ten

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TERRY PLUTO

Wilkins has Mass appeal — in one way

AKRON — Father Paul Shindler has been the pastor at St. Bernard's for 14 years. He is the kind of guy who watches all the local pro teams on TV and keeps track of their games on the radio and in the newspaper. That was why he was so stunned to see Lenny Wilkins in the pews one morning.

It was 10 years ago, and Wilkins had just become the coach of the Cavs. Shindler was saying a 7:10 morning Mass. It was the middle of the week, and there were only a few folks in a huge church.

"I just looked up from the altar, and I saw Lenny," Shindler recalled. "Then I started to see him all the time. If the Cavs were in town, he was at morning Mass. If they played a Sunday afternoon game, somehow he got out of the Coliseum and made it to our 4:30 afternoon Mass. I never figured how he did it."

Wilkins is in town again tonight. Only now, the Cavs are at Gund Arena, and he is coaching the Atlanta Hawks.

For seven years, he lived on Ghent Road in Akron. He was a regular at such restaurants as Jack Horner's, Papa Joe's and The Courtyard in Brecksville.

The man who won his 1,000th game last week ... a coach who has won more games than anyone else in NBA history ... one who will never have the Hollywood-type popularity of the high-profile coaches ... well, the key to his longevity may be found in those quiet mornings at St. Bernard's.

"Lenny usually sat near the back," Shindler said. "The people who saw him knew that Lenny was there to pray and think. It was not for show. He wasn't there to be seen. Our people didn't bother him, except maybe to say hello. They respected why he was in church."

It was there that Wilkins met Sister Kathy McIntyre.

"I went to the morning Mass at St. Bernard's," she said. "I started to see Lenny there — a lot. At first, I just wished him and his team luck."

One morning, Wilkins invited Sister Kathy to have breakfast with him and his wife. Soon, Marilyn Wilkins and Sister Kathy had become close, and the nun visited the Wilkins family in Atlanta last summer.

If you want to know why Wilkins has survived for 23 years as an NBA coach, consider the company he keeps. His friends are priests and nuns. They are people such as Akron Judge James Williams and former teammate Barry Clemens.

It is not a star-studded cast, but Wilkins is not a Hollywood kind of guy.

"Lenny always has both feet on the ground," Clemens said. "When you are around him, you sense this inner peace. As my wife says, he is a very quiet but a very sweet man."

Clemens is now a stockbroker in Cleveland. He played with Wilkins in Seattle in the 1960s and with the Cavs in the 1970s.

"When Lenny broke Red Auerbach's record (938 career victories), he sent me this (plaque) to hang on the wall," Clemens said. "In each corner is the name and logo of the four teams he coached — Cleveland, Seattle, Portland and Atlanta. In the middle, he wrote that I helped him to a lot of those victories."

Clemens insists that Wilkins will never be truly appreciated. Part of the reason is that he has poached in backwater towns.

"When Pat Riley does some-

See PLUTO, B2

Julio sees ways of his errors

Steve Herrick
The Chronicle-Telegram

WINTER HAVEN, Fla. — Julio Franco isn't going to let his problems at first base get him down.

"The first couple of days when you come to a new club, you want to impress everybody," he said. "You try too hard. I'm just going to forget about it and do things my way."

Franco's troubles at first have many eyes in camp watching him. After making three errors in the first intrasquad game last

week, Franco couldn't come up with two low throws and was hit with a pickoff throw in Friday's exhibition opener. In Monday's game against Kansas City, he threw to the wrong base after fielding a ground ball and booted another grounder in the same inning.

Despite these troubles, Franco is taking a what-me-worry approach.

"I've been wanting to do too much," he said. "I'm going to take one thing at a time and go from there."

Franco sat out Wednesday's

game after taking a knee from Royals shortstop Jose Offerman in the left side of the face on Tuesday. The injury occurred when Franco was trying to break up a double play on a ball hit to the pitcher.

"I was coming hard into second base and it was a low throw," said Franco. "Before he could get out of the way, I was right on top of him. His knee hit me right in the cheekbone."

Franco was face down on the ground for several minutes before being helped off the field.

"I thought my jaw was bro-

ken," he said. "The left side of my face was numb. I've been hit with pitches before, but I've never been hit that hard in my life."

Franco still had a bruise under his left eye and a headache on Wednesday. He was sent home to rest before the game. Mike Hargrove hopes Franco will be able to play today against Florida.

Franco thinks part of his problem at first has been a result of thinking too much.

"First base is one of the easi-

See FRANCO, B2



Steve Herrick
with the
Indians

HIGH SCHOOL BASKETBALL

Falls charges past Firelands

Tim Gebhardt
The Chronicle-Telegram

LORAIN — Impressive, very impressive.

That's the only way to describe Olmsted Falls Wednesday night against Firelands in the Admiral King Division II boys district semifinal.

The Bulldogs put on a basketball clinic in destroying a very capable Firelands team, 79-41, to move to Saturday's final against the winner of tonight's Elyria West-Rocky River contest.

Want to see power inside? How about an outside touch? Defense? Rebounding? Free throw shooting?

Name just about any aspect of the sport and Olmsted Falls did it — and did it well. Falls, the top seed in the King field, is now 20-2. Firelands finished a very successful season at 16-6.

"Nothing you can do," said Mike Horne, Firelands coach, when asked what his team might have done differently. "We tried to play straight up with them the first half, not doubling down on (Tim) Schaefer, and he had a bucket of points."

Schaefer had 17 of his game-high 21 points in the first half. Firelands' adjustments in the second half didn't help.

"We tried to double down," Horne said, "and they just kicked the ball back out. That's what you can do when you have the classic inside-outside game."

"We had to establish an

Weather forces postponements

Storms forced postponement of Wednesday's Division III regional girls game between Columbia and Coldwater at Bucyrus High School, plus the Division II district semifinal boys game between Vermilion and Lexington at Ashland College.

Columbia's game was rescheduled for tonight at 6:15. Vermilion's game will be played tonight at 8.

The Division I boys district championship game at Midview, between St. Edward and Strongsville, has been shifted to Saturday at 7 p.m. It was originally scheduled for Friday.

inside game," said Falls coach Pat Donahue, "knowing full well it would force their guards to double-down and sag off. We have some kids who can put them in the basket. We knew we'd get those shots if we got the inside game going."

Perhaps by expending all its energy on the defensive end, and perhaps intimidated by the presence of not only the 6-foot-8 junior Schaefer but 6-8 senior Nick Neumeister as well, Firelands never got untracked offensively.

The Falcons hit just 3-of-19 shots from the floor the first

See FALLS, B4



KIMBERLY BARTH / CHRONICLE

ON THE INSIDE: Olmsted Falls' Tim Schaefer, right, scores two of his game-high 21 points.

Uncommon cold hits Amherst

Steve Byrne
The Chronicle-Telegram

GRAFTON — Amherst didn't get the shooting it normally gets, and usually needs, to win.

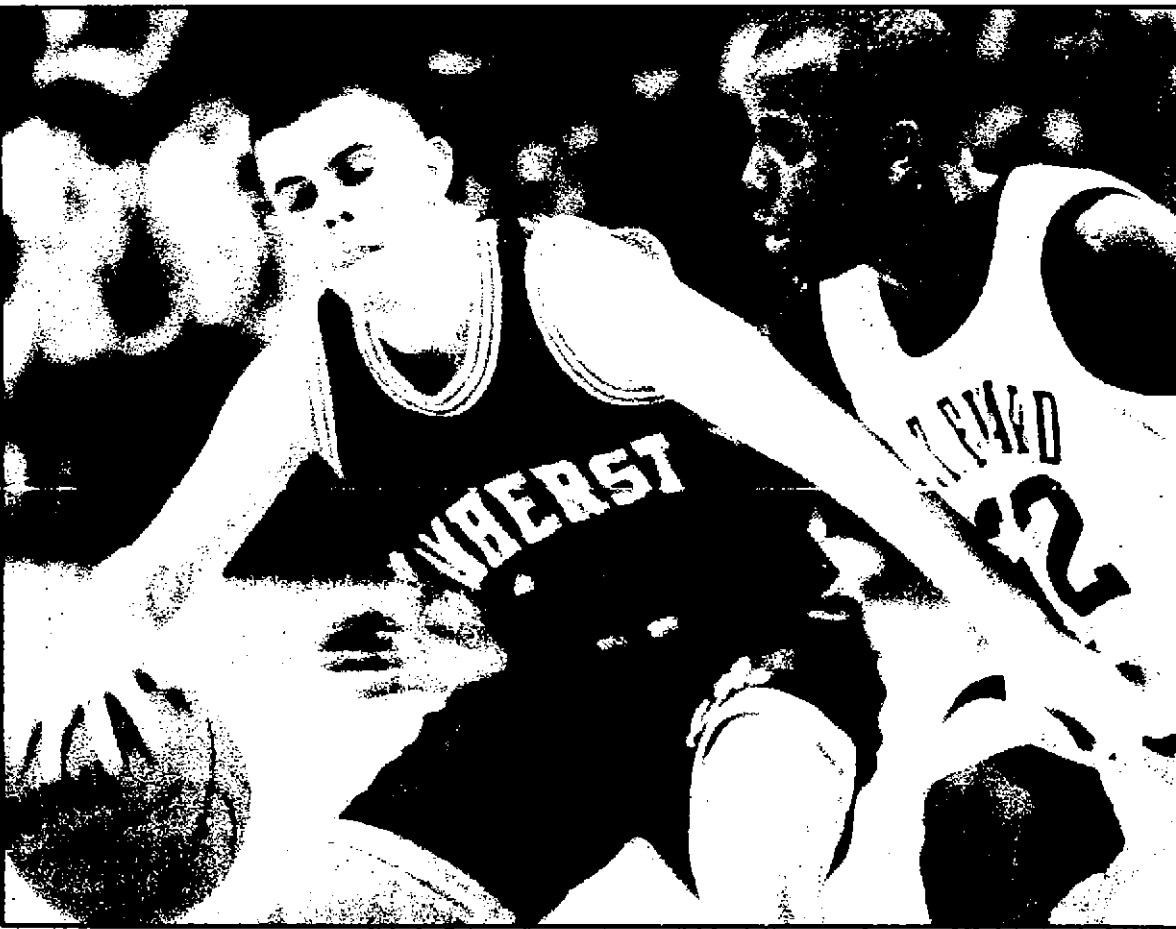
That was what both coaches — Dave Zvara of Amherst and Greg Zimmermann of St. Edward — said was the biggest reason St. Ed pounded the Comets 71-52 in their semifinal game in the Division I Midview District tournament on Wednesday.

The second-seeded Eagles, the highest seed left in the tournament, will play Strongsville Saturday for the district championship. St. Ed's last won the tournament in 1989; Strongsville in 1990.

"We missed so many shots we gave up a lot of layups in transition," Zvara said. "We know we have to shoot better than that to win. Transition baskets and the fact we didn't handle their press well made the difference."

The Comets made only 11-of-30 field goal attempts through the first three quarters. They also committed 18 turnovers to

See AMHERST, B4



TOM MAHL / CHRONICLE

REACH FOR IT: Steve Logan of St. Edward (22) tries to knock the ball away from Amherst's Kris White.

Physical & unfit Indiana whips withering OSU

Rusty Miller
Associated Press

COLUMBUS — All season long, Ohio State has tried to make do without a true center. Indiana wasn't fooled one bit.

Exploiting Ohio State's skinny, undersized front line, Todd Lindeman muscled his way to a career-high 28 points as the Hoosiers brushed aside the Buckeyes 73-56 Wednesday night.

"They were much too physical for us," said coach Randy Ayers, whose Buckeyes have lost eight of their last nine and 11 of 13. "They saw where our weakness was. Obviously, we did not have the matchups from a physical standpoint."

The victory vaulted the Hoosiers (18-11, 11-6 in the Big Ten) into a tie for second place in the conference with Penn State, which lost at Wisconsin.

Lindeman was an unlikely star, at least in terms of free-throw shooting. He came in shooting 50 percent for the season at the line. In his college career, the 7-foot senior had never scored more than 21 points, shot more than eight free throws or made more than six foul shots in a game.

But with the Hoosiers pounding the ball inside, he hit 14-of-16 free throws to go with 7-of-13 shooting from the field.

"We came in hoping to take it inside on them," Lindeman said. "We tried to pound it inside and get them in foul trouble. That's just what we did."

He said practice was the reason he suddenly became a marksman at the line.

See OSU, B2

Vermilion standouts honored

Vermilion stars Kristi Middleton and Ed Cyrek were honored by a media panel picking the Associated Press' all-district basketball teams for Northwest Ohio.

Middleton, a 5-foot-8 senior, made the girls first team in Division II. A three-year letter-winner, she averaged 15.6 points, 8.7 rebounds and 5.3 assists. Vermilion shared the Erie Shore Conference championship and finished with a 16-6 record.

Middleton, an all-conference and all-county first teamer, holds the Vermilion record for a game with 22 rebounds.

Cyrek, a 6-3 senior, made the all-district third team for boys. He averages 15.9 points a game for a Sailor team that will take a 15-7 record into the district semifinals against Lexington tonight.



Middleton

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